
A Wider Life

How a life gets narrow,
and how it widens again



Ahmed Abuelhaz

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A book for someone whose life has got narrow, and who cannot say when it happened.

Sixteen chapters in four parts: why it got narrow, and then how it widens.

And a fifth part on the app that walks the journey with you.

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The promise

This is a book for someone whose life has got narrow, and who cannot say when it happened.

Nothing struck him. Nobody died, he did not lose his job, his house did not fall in. Everything is in its place, and still each day is narrower than the last, and the things that used to lift him pass through without leaving a mark, and he sits with the people closest to him and gets up from the chair exactly as he sat down.

And he knows. **That is the real problem: he knows everything.** He knows that late nights wreck his mornings, that the screen takes his attention, that measuring himself against what he sees of other people eats at him. He knows more about himself than his father ever knew about himself. And then he does not move.

So you are not short of information. You are not short of advice. You are short of structure.

Short of something that tells you: you are here now, the thing happening in you is called this, your next step is exactly this, and when two things pull against each other, this one comes first.

That is what this book is. One complete map: what you are made of, what narrows your life, what the opposite of it is, and how to walk through a

real day with work in it and children in it and a phone that will not stay quiet.

How to read it

Read it in order the first time, because the four parts are built on each other. After that, open it anywhere.

Part One says why it got narrow. That is a description, not a charge. **Part Two** is the map: what you are made of, what narrows you, and what the opposite is. **Part Three** is the four circles: yourself, your home, your work, your people. **Part Four** is the heaviest in weight and the lightest to read: how to walk through a day and a week, what to do when you stop, and how to leave. **And a short Part Five:** the app that walks this journey with you, and how you enter it.

Every chapter ends with one act in three doses. **Take the dose you know you will do, not the one you would like to be the kind of person who does.**

And what this book is not

It is not a programme that starts on Monday and collapses on Thursday. It is not a promise that you will be a different person in thirty days. It is not a charge against you for what has already gone.

And one thing has to be said on the first page: this book hands you a tool you work with yourself. So if you need it in a year the way you need it today, it has failed. **Its success is that you need it less.**

And if what is on you is heavier than this, if the narrowing keeps you from sleeping or eating or working month after month, then this book is not enough on its own. There is nothing shameful in looking for someone who does this well, where you live, and it is no failure in you and none in your will. **There is a whole page on this on page 39. Open it now if this is about you.**

And the first week

This is written before you begin, because the first week is the most dangerous week in the whole thing, **and not because it is the hardest. Because it is the most misleading.**

In the first week the book is still in your head, the act is still new, and the enthusiasm is working. So one of two things will happen: either you do the act and feel that nothing has changed, or you forget and say a word about yourself.

Both are expected. **Because the first week does not measure.** What measures is the week with no enthusiasm in it, and that one arrives in the third or the fourth.

So three things are wanted from you in the first seven days, and no more:

- **One act.** Not two, and not two circles.
- **One dose,** and take it smaller than you think you can manage.
- **And pass no verdict.** Not on the act, not on yourself, and not on the book.

And the commonest thing that brings people down in the first week is not that they did not do it. It is that they held a court. They open the sheet on day four, see two boxes filled and five empty, and say a sentence about themselves. **That sentence is what stops the thing, not the five empty boxes.**

So if the first week passes and you did the act once, **you are exactly where you should be.** And if it passes and you did not do it at all, and you opened the sheet again the week after, **you are exactly where you should be as well.**

PART ONE

Why it got narrow

A diagnosis, not a charge. What happened to you, and
when, and why it is not weakness in you.

A man who knows everything and does not move

In two lines

There is no missing piece of information between you and a wider life. What is between you and it is **an order of operations**. This chapter shows you why everything you already know has not landed in your day yet, and why that is not weakness in you.

A day that kept repeating

I was thirty three.

I would wake after four hours of sleep. Not wake, exactly. I would force myself up. And I would go to the gym before the office, because I could still make myself do one thing a day, and that was the one.

Then the office until eight at night.

Then home, and the sofa, and the phone, and scrolling until I fell asleep. Not watching anything. Scrolling.

And my head, the whole time, in one place: what the company did today, which numbers had problems in them, what I wanted to work on next.

That was every day.

And at the time I owned a company whose entire work was helping a person whose life had got narrow find someone to talk to.

What stopped me later was not that I was tired. What stopped me was that **I knew**. I knew four hours is not sleep. I knew that sitting on the sofa was not rest. I knew what my own company told people every day.

And I was going to the gym. So the will was there. **A man who drags himself up on four hours of sleep to go and train is not a lazy man.**

So what I was missing was not willpower, and it was not information. **What I was missing was an order.**

Knowing a thing and being able to do it are two different things

If you had asked me about myself then, I would have given you an analysis sharper than most people could. I knew the name of what was happening to me, I knew roughly when it started, I knew the screen was part of it.

Then you ask me: **and what will you do tonight?** You will find me quiet.

Because the distance between knowing and doing is not crossed with more information. That distance has a name, and the name is **order**: what comes before what, what gets left for now because its time has not come, and what size my own day can carry, not somebody else's day.

So I bought a new book every time I felt the narrowing, and I did not need a book. I needed to decide on one smallest act and do it for three nights.

Plenty of medicine and no index

There were two doors in front of me, and each one is half a door.

The first door is going back to old writing, written hundreds of years ago. You read pages that describe your own interior with a precision that startles you, and then you close the book, impressed and unmoved. Not because the writing has lost its force, but because it was written for someone living inside a different order: a wide house with elders in it, time carved up for him from outside, one man who knew his name and his fault and would say it to his face, and work with a door that closed. **So he has the deepest pharmacy people have ever built, and the index that gets the medicine to the right person is lost.**

The second door is the modern habit books. These are excellent at indexing: numbered steps, one small habit a day, an app that measures and reminds. But they will not tell you what a person is, or who he belongs to, or where any of it ends. They treat your narrowing the way a fault in a machine gets treated. **So they have the index and they do not have the medicine.**

The damage is the same in both cases, and its name is **there is no structure.**

And why in your time in particular

Your grandfather did not build his structure himself. He was born inside one.

The order came to him from outside: people around him who arranged his day, and time divided up for him by markers he did not choose and did not hear from a phone, and one man who knew his fault and named it, so the fault did not go on growing in the dark for twenty years, and work that ended at a place, so it did not follow him to his bed.

And then that weight was taken off him in a single generation. The next chapter will tell you how, and why.

So now you build for yourself what used to be built for you. That is not a shortage of advice. That is a shortage of architecture.

And the narrowing has an exact name

Take the definition precisely, because everything after this is built on it:

Narrowing is not poverty, and it is not illness, and it is not bad luck. It is that everything is present and the space is small.

That is a description of a condition, not a verdict on you. **It is what happens when the connection to meaning is cut:** the days remain, the work remains, the people remain, and the space that holds you among them shrinks. It happens to the religious and to the irreligious, to the one who has made it and to the one who is still trying, so it is no sign of a defect in your character and no reason to stop reading.

And if narrowing is the name of the illness, width is the name of the cure. That is why the book is called what it is called. It is not a promise of happiness, because happiness is a state that comes and goes and nothing can be built on it. **Width is something else: that your life becomes wide enough for what is in it.**

And why what you tried before did not work

Because every time, you started at the end of the chain.

You decided to sleep early, and read every day, and keep off the screen after ten, and be more patient with your children. Four decisions in one night, all of them visible acts, and all of them hanging in the air: **there is no body underneath them to carry them, no state before them pushing you toward them, no picture behind them that makes them mean anything.**

So all four fell inside a week. Not because you are weak, but because nobody told you they have an order, and that a layer is not repaired by the layer above it. A man trying to fix his temper on four nights of no sleep is fixing the roof while the foundation shifts.

That order is what Part Two opens.

And the smallest thing to begin with

Before you start, take one line that compresses the whole book:

**The measure is not the size of the act. The measure
is that it lasts.**

What does not last does not count, however large it was. That one line strikes out half of what you have written in your lists, and raises the value of the small thing you kept dismissing.

How an act is written

- 1 Small enough to make you laugh.
- 2 Hung on something that happens in your day, never on a time on the clock.
- 3 Carrying a sign you can touch, so you know you did it.
- 4 Able to shrink: the same act made smaller, not an easier different act.

These four are taken apart one by one in chapter 13. Take them as they are for now, and go back to them there when you need them.

The action

One act, one night. Choose something that already happens in your day and does not need you to remember it: the first time you sit at your desk, or after the last meal of the day, or as your head goes down on the pillow.

Dose	The act
Full	At that moment, write three lines: where exactly your life got narrow today, at what hour, and with whom
Half	One line: where it got narrow
Smallest	One word for the narrowing, any word that comes to you

The sign that you moved: after three nights you find yourself writing the same word. What repeats three times is not a mood that passed, and that is the first thread in your hand.

And do not write down why you failed yesterday. There is no box for failure in this book, and there will not be one.

Your life did not get narrow overnight

In two lines

What happened to you happened to a whole generation, and it did not happen because you are weaker than your father. **Four things arrived, and four things left.** This chapter gives you the whole account, not to excuse you, but so you stop fighting an enemy you think is in your chest when it is in your room.

Four things were carrying you and they left

Your grandfather was not stronger in will than you. He was carried.

He had a house with elders in it. He did not decide when to eat or when to visit; the order existed before he did. **And his time was divided for him from outside.** His day was not one block, it was cut into pieces by markers happening around him that he had not chosen: a meal at its hour, a shop that opened and shut, an hour when everyone around him stopped at once. So he never had to decide when to stop. **And there was one man who knew his fault and would name it to his face,** someone who had known him since he was small and did not flatter him, so the fault did not go on growing in the dark for twenty years. **And his work ended at a**

place, a door that closed and a shop that was locked, so the work did not follow him to his bed.

Four things were carrying for him what you are now carrying alone. **And they did not go because you sent them away. They went in one generation, and nobody asked you.**

And three arrived that you can see

The first: a flood of words. More is put in front of you in a single day than was put in front of your father in a year, with no index to order it. Knowing more becomes a weight in itself, because every piece of correct advice contradicts the one before it: this one says get up at five, that one says sleep eight hours, the third says ignore both and listen to your body. **A man with too much evidence and no scale to weigh it with sits down.**

The second: an industry that sells nothing but your time. The screen in your hand is not neutral. It is not a notebook waiting for you to open it, it is a thing built with enormous care so that you will not settle, because your settling is a loss on somebody's ledger. They test the colours of the buttons on you, and the order of what appears, and the hour the notification lands, and they measure across hundreds of millions of people which version holds your eye longest. **And you think of yourself as weak willed, while you are wrestling something designed to beat you.**

And it does not only take your time, it takes something dearer: **it gives you a tribe that is angry alongside you.** Every day someone tells you that you are right and everyone else is wrong, not because he knows you, but

because your anger keeps you seated. So your heart narrows toward people while you believe you have become more clear sighted.

The third: a machine that has started arguing with you about your oldest question. What is it that makes me distinct as a person, and what is my effort and my mind worth if the thing I do in an hour is done elsewhere in a second? That is a heavy question no generation before you had to face, and it is being set on you while you are busy with this month's bills.

And a softness that has a price nobody sees

And there is a fourth that nobody feels, because it arrives dressed as a gift.

Everything is nearer to you than it was to anyone before you. Food arrives at your door, the answer arrives before you have finished the question, and waiting has been abolished entirely. **And what goes with waiting is your tolerance.** A man who has never waited a week for anything finds it hard to hold steady for a year. So life softens around you and your endurance softens with it, and you find yourself breaking over things your father would have walked past without turning his head.

And there is one line that names the whole of it:

**Distraction is not prevention. Nobody prevented
you.**

Distraction is being occupied by one thing instead of another until the life is over and you are still occupied. That is the narrowing exactly: a

whole life passed while you were busy, and if you were asked with what, you could not answer.

And this is an explanation, not an excuse

And here is a part that has to be said plainly, or the whole chapter turns into a hook to hang things on.

Knowing the weight is heavy is one thing, and sitting down because it is heavy is another. Whoever reads this chapter and comes out of it saying “so it is not my fault” has taken half of it and left half. The other half is that you now know exactly where your enemy is, **and that most of what you are fighting is not in your chest, it is in your room and in your pocket and in the order of your day.** That is good news, because what is in the room changes in a minute, and what is in the chest takes years.

And you are not required to carry what you cannot carry:

What cannot be lifted was never asked of you.

And it is you who set yourself four decisions in one night. Nobody else did that.

And this reverses the order of treatment

If most of what narrows you is in your surroundings and not in you, **then the cheapest change, and the fastest to take effect, is to change something in your place and not in your intentions.**

A man who decides to resist his phone with his will every night has entered a fight he will usually lose. A man who put the charger in another room ended the fight before it began. That is not a trick and it is not self deception, **it is a correct reading of where the battle is.** Will is a scarce fortune, so do not spend it on something that rearranging a room would have done.

The action

Change one thing in your place, not in yourself. Something physical, that you can see with your eyes, and that does not need you to remember it every night. **And your place does not have to be large.** Whoever has a spare room can use it, and whoever has one room for himself and his children has the same law with other tools: **what works is the distance between you and the thing, not the size of the house. And your place does not have to be large.** Whoever has a spare room can use it, and whoever has one room for himself and his children has the same law with other tools: **what works is the distance between you and the thing, not the size of the house.**

Dose	The act
Full	Move the phone charger out of your reach while you sleep, tonight. And if there is no other room, then a high shelf, or a bag, or a shoe by the door. What matters is that you have to stand up to reach it
Half	Turn the phone face down somewhere your hand cannot reach from the bed
Smallest	Turn off one notification for one app, tonight

The sign that you moved: after three nights you notice that you reached out your hand, found nothing, and then slept. Do not wait to feel something enormous. **The sign is small, in proportion to the act.**

The heart is a mirror and dust settles

In two lines

This is the most important chapter in the book. There is one picture in it, and if you understand it you have understood everything after it: **your heart is a mirror, and what happens to it is not breaking, it is dust.** And whoever is waiting for something large to happen before he moves has the small things settling on him until he cannot see.

A man who did not know his own voice

He found an old video on his phone, three years old. He had been filming something else entirely, and he was talking in the background.

He stopped at his own voice.

Not because the voice had changed. The voice was the same. But in the video there is someone hurrying to the end of the sentence so he can laugh, and there is a note in it that asks a question without wanting anything back. And today he speaks in a shorter sentence, in a voice that finishes early.

He sat there thinking: what happened?

Nothing happened. There is no day he can put his finger on and say that was it. No large quarrel, no loss, nobody hurt him. If you asked him what had changed in three years he would say: nothing. Roughly the same work, roughly the same people, the same house.

And still the man in the video is not him.

Then he started counting small things. That he answers messages while walking. That he stopped sitting down at the table. That he listens to the first thirty seconds of anything and says he has got it. That he says "fine" in places where he used to say words.

And each one of them, looked at on its own, made him laugh, because it really is nothing.

And it really is nothing. And together they are the man in the video.

The mirror and the dust

Picture a clean mirror. It shows you your face as it is, without needing any effort from you, because that is its nature.

Now leave it for a month in a room with an open window. Nothing will break, and you will hear nothing happen. Every day one particle lands on it, too small for the eye. After a month you pass it and find your reflection dulled, and you assume your face is what changed.

That is exactly how a life gets narrow. Not by one large event, but by a layer that builds out of the small and repeated: a glance here, an hour lost in nothing, a word about your brother behind his back, an outburst never

apologised for, a small promise not kept. Not one of them is enough on its own to leave a mark. All of them together are enough.

The first law: the small and repeated is more dangerous than the large and rare

This is the opposite of what people believe, and the reason is simple.

Large things hurt. Whoever falls into something large feels it at the time, so he regrets it, so he comes back. The pain itself is the door back, which is why many of the people who fell into something large became better afterwards than they were.

Small things do not hurt. Nothing in you moves, so nothing calls you back, so it repeats. And then it repeats. And then it becomes a nature you are not aware of, and you defend it if someone points it out.

So the most dangerous thing in you is not the worst thing you ever did.

The most dangerous thing in you is the thing you do every day and do not consider a thing at all.

The second law: dust hides, it does not replace

The mirror under the dust is a mirror. It has not turned to stone.

This is the most important part of the picture, because it stops you passing a final sentence on yourself. A man who says “I am a bad person” has described the mirror as broken, and it is not broken, it is covered. **And the difference between broken and covered is the difference between despair and work.**

That is why you will not find one line in this book telling you that you are beyond hope. Not because it is a flattering book, but because that would be the opposite of the truth.

The third law: every dust has a cloth of its own kind

Dust does not come off by talking about it. It comes off with a cloth of the opposite.

So if what narrows you is anger, its opposite is an act that holds the tongue in the moment, not a lecture on patience. If it is attachment to what other people have, its opposite is seeing what is in your own hands. If it is hardness, its opposite is getting close to one person who needs you, close enough to see him with your eyes, not reading about compassion.

The cure is of the same kind as the illness and its opposite at the same time. That is why the map in Part Two has two halves and not one: what narrows, and what widens.

Three questions to put to anything in you

This is the practical tool you will use through the whole book. Take anything you complain of in yourself and ask three questions about it, no more:

The question	What you are looking for
What does it darken in me?	What have I stopped seeing because of it

The question	What you are looking for
What good thing does it block?	What would I have done if it were not there
What is its opposite that clears it?	One small act of the opposite kind, done today

Try them now on the first thing that came into your head. **You will find the third question the hardest, and it is the only one of the three that moves anything.**

And be careful not to turn this into a courtroom

There is a place in all this where the cure turns into the illness.

A man who takes this picture and starts inspecting himself every night the way a prosecutor inspects, not a doctor, comes out of it with a heavy gloom and no movement. That is not what is meant, and it is not near it. **The point is to know so that you can work, not to know so that you can convict yourself.**

And know that a break that leaves you needing other people is better for a man than a hardness that leaves you above them. Whoever sees his fault and grows gentler toward other people has gained by the sight of it. Whoever sees his fault and despises himself and sits down has traded one dust for another.

And that is the ceiling of this whole book: it passes no sentence on anyone, and none on you.

The action

Choose one small act you do every day and do not consider a thing. Not the largest thing in you, but **the most repeated thing in you**.

Dose	The act
Full	Stop it three times today, and after each time write one word for what you felt
Half	Stop it once, once only, and watch what happens in you in the minute afterwards
Smallest	Do not stop it. Just name it to yourself in the moment you are doing it, and say “this is it”

The sign that you moved: the moment itself starts becoming visible to you before you act, not after. **Whoever sees before he acts owns something he did not own.**

Why one act widens you and the same act narrows you

In two lines

One act is not one thing. Two people do the same thing, and one comes out of it wider and the other narrower. The difference is not in the act, **the difference is in what moved him to it.** This chapter makes that into something you use, not something you admire.

Two men in the same office

Two men work the same hours at the same company.

The first works with his eye on what will be said about him. He rewrites the message four times, not so it will be understood, but so he will not look weak. He is genuinely tired, and he goes home empty, **because the one working was not him, it was his fear of his own image.** Every time he is praised his hunger grows, and every time people go quiet about him his unease grows.

The second does the same work, and is tired in the same way, and goes home with something left over. Not because he is less careful, but because for him the work is a living to be earned and a trust to be kept and a household to be held up, **so it is not hanging on what anyone says about him.**

The hours are the same, and the office is the same, and the outcome in the two lives is completely different.

And there is one line that holds the whole chapter:

An act runs on what moved you, not on what you said.

And what moved you is not a sentence you say

Most people think of intention as a sentence said quietly before an act. That is the smallest part of it.

What moved you is what actually pushed you. It is the honest answer to one question: why did I get up from my chair just now? You may say one thing with your tongue while something else is doing the moving.

That is why it is not known by thinking about it, **it is known by its trace:** if the act stopped when the praise stopped, you have learned what was driving it.

The chain before any act

To catch this in a real day, look at how any act actually happens in you. Five links one after the other, passing in seconds:

A thought crosses, then **a leaning** happens, then **a decision** is taken, then **a resolve** hardens, then **an act** falls.

Take an example from your own night: you are lying down, and the thought crosses, “check the phone.” If it had stopped there it would have been nothing, because thoughts cross everyone and nobody is asked about them. Then something in you leans a little, then you say “one minute,” then the hand reaches. Then you look at the clock and it is forty minutes.

And the place to work is not the last link. A man fighting at the fifth link, with the phone already in his hand, is fighting in the narrowest spot and in his weakest state. A man who has trained himself to stop at the second link, at the leaning, never needed a fight at all.

That is the skill of this whole book in one line: move the fight to an earlier link.

And what moves you gathers, it does not come alone

There is a mistake everybody makes when they first come to this. They go looking for one clean motive behind an act, they cannot find it, they give up, and they drop the act entirely.

What moves a single act gathers. Take a man who goes to the gym three times a week, and there are three things in him: he wants his body to be better, and his friend is going with him so he was ashamed to be the one who did not, and he likes being seen there. Three in one act, and that is the condition of most people, and it is not proof of rot.

The right question is not: is this clean? It is: which one of these would have been enough on its own?

So if your friend had not gone, and the place had been empty, would you still have gone? If the answer is yes, you are fine even with the rest gathered alongside it. If the answer is no, you have learned what to work on, **without dropping the act itself.**

And a limit not to cross

And here is a plain ceiling: **do not turn this question into a courtroom where you sentence yourself.**

What moves you hides, and hides deeply, to the point where a man can believe one thing moved him when it was another. Anyone who wants certainty about it will never do anything at all, and that paralysis is what happens to people who take this badly.

So keep it as a **sorting question when things are unclear**, not a scale you weigh every movement on. **You do not have the authority to pass a final sentence on yourself, and neither does anyone else.**

And why this widens a life

Because most of what narrows you is not the size of what you do, it is doing it without knowing why.

A whole day of work and traffic and messages, if it has a direction you know, passes heavy but does not pass narrow. **The direction does not change the acts, it changes what you take from them.**

That is why this book will not ask you to delete half your day. It will ask for something cheaper: that you know why you are doing what you were going to do anyway.

The action

Choose one act you will do tomorrow, from your work or your home.

Dose	The act
Full	Before you do it, ask yourself: if nobody would ever know about it, would I do it? Then do it, and write one line on what showed
Half	Ask the question only, without writing
Smallest	Before the act, say to yourself who you are doing it for. One word, then carry on

The sign that you moved: mid week you find an act you were going to do and then did not, not because you stopped yourself, **but because you found no answer when you asked.**

By now **four acts** have passed you. Still **only one** is running. What went by was an offer, not a demand.

PART TWO

The map

What you are made of, what narrows your life, and what
the opposite of it is.

Six layers

In two lines

You are not a list of traits. You are six layers stacked on each other, and most attempts fail because people treat a layer with the layer above it. This chapter gives you the order, and then the law that governs movement between them.

Why layers and not traits

Ask a man about himself and he will count out scattered traits: a bit short tempered, generous, useless in the mornings, loves his family. That is a list you cannot act on, because it does not tell you which one to start with or which one is causing which.

Layers tell you that. What is underneath carries what is above, so if what is underneath has shifted, you cannot repair what is above however hard you work at it.

The layers

0 • your body. Your sleep, your food, your movement, what you look at. This is the layer nobody counts in this field, and it is the one that brings most people down. A man who has not slept for four nights and then shouted at his son does not have a patience problem. **The body is a real entrance to the interior, not a servant to it.**

1 · what you do. What people see of you: what you say, what you leave, how you treat the person who cannot answer you back. This is the fastest layer to change and the least stable if there is nothing under it.

2 · your state. What is passing over you today: tight or open, willing or flat. **This layer is moving by nature, so decisions are not built on it.** A man who decided his future on a narrow night decided with something other than his mind.

3 · what sits inside you. What is settled in you and repeats and does not leave when its cause leaves: attachment to what other people hold, or love of praise, or discomfort at something good in someone else's hands. This layer is the largest field of this book, and the next two chapters take it.

4 · what you think it is all for. Your silent answer to one question: what is all of this for? Nobody is usually asked about it, and it is what decides the meaning of everything below it. **A man with no answer here finds everything below it tasteless, and does not know why.**

5 · that it ends. That this finishes, and that something of you stays after you. If this layer is missing, every reckoning in a life is a short reckoning, because the only measure left is these near years on their own.

And a plain line about the last two layers: this book **does not give you an answer** to “what is all of this for?” or to “and then what.” That answer is not its business and not its right. **What it says is that both questions exist, and that a man living as though there were no question is paying a price and does not know what he is paying it for.** Your answer, from wherever you got it, is what makes those two layers work.

The law of movement between layers

Three laws, and they save a great deal of talk:

The first: a layer is repaired by the one beneath it, not the one above it.

So a man who wants to repair what he does starts from his body, not from decisions he writes down. And a man who wants to repair what sits inside him will not get there by suppressing the visible act.

The second: what is below builds what is above, slowly. A repeated act changes what sits inside you after months, without your noticing. That is the other face of the dust in the last chapter: **as dust settles by repetition, it lifts by repetition.**

The third: do not diagnose one layer in the language of another.

Morning sluggishness may be body and not conduct, and a flat week may be state and not interior. **The commonest way people flog themselves is holding the body to account as though it were a failure of character.**

Two men with the same complaint, and one who moved

Two friends, each complaining of the same thing: **I lose my temper with my children over small things.**

The first worked on the thing itself. He decided to count to ten before answering. He read about patience. He set a reminder on his phone at noon that said “be calm.” And every night after he lost it he went over himself.

He held three days, then went back. **So he had added a new piece to the story: he had tried and failed.**

The second asked one question before deciding anything: **when exactly does this happen?**

So for a week he wrote one line each time. Then he looked at the sheet: six of the seven fell between six and eight in the evening. **After a full day of work, before food, on five or six hours of sleep.**

So he did not work on his temper. He worked on six o'clock.

He slept half an hour earlier for a fortnight. He ate something small when he got in, before sitting with them. **And he read not one word about patience.**

After a month the thing had grown less. Not gone, less. **And he found he could now do what the first man had been trying to do,** hold quiet a moment before answering, because what took that out of him was gone.

Both were honest, and both saw the same problem. The difference is that one worked on the layer the complaint showed in, **and the other went down to the first layer beneath it that had something wrong.**

Where do you start

One rule: **start from the lowest layer that has something wrong with it.**

So if your sleep is a wreck, you have no business in this book tonight except sleep. If your body is steady and what you do is unsteady, start from what you do. And do not climb until what is below has held for two weeks.

This is the hardest thing in the book on a person, because the upper layers are more beautiful and more dignified, and something in us wants to

start up there. Whoever starts from the roof has built in the air.

The action

Dose	The act
Full	Write the six layers on a sheet, and put one word next to each: sound, or unsettled. Then underline the first unsettled one from the bottom
Half	Write the first two only: your body and what you do
Smallest	Answer one question: how many hours a night did you sleep this week, on average?

The sign that you moved: you stop trying to fix the one thing you have been trying to fix for a year, **because you have worked out that it is not the start of the road.**

Something passing and something that lives in you

In two lines

Before you go into the map of what narrows your life, you need to know the difference between something passing over you and something living in you. **A man who treats a passing thing as a settled illness has exhausted himself for nothing**, and that is the commonest thing that happens to anyone reading in this field.

Two days do not make a verdict

You wake one day with no appetite for anything. The thing you do every day is heavy, the work is heavy, people are heavy. So you say “my heart has gone hard.”

And perhaps it has not. Perhaps you slept five hours for three nights, or a piece of news reached you yesterday that you have not digested, or you are in the days of the month when everything weighs more. **This passes over the best people exactly as it passes over everyone else, and it has passed over the best people you have known.**

How to tell them apart

Three distinctions are enough, and you do not need more with them:

	Passing	Living in you
How long	Days or a week	Months and years
Relation to its cause	Goes when the cause goes	Stays even if every cause is removed
Where it shows	In one area of your life	In every circle: your home, your work, your road

Tightness because of a difficult manager goes when he goes. **Tightness that follows you home and on holiday and to another country is something else.**

And there is a fourth question that comes before those three, and it prevents the largest mistake in the table: **is the cause still standing?** A man who lost someone, a woman who cares for a parent who is ill, a man whose marriage ended, a man whose country turned over · **their causes are still standing and still working every day**, and it is not in their hands to remove them. If they answer that it follows them everywhere and that it stays, they will come out of this table with a verdict that something is settled wrong in them, **and that is not true. What cannot be lifted is not being asked of you.** Your work with it is not to cure yourself of it. Your work is to find one small thing you can do inside a thing you cannot do anything about.

One whose manager left, and one who moved country

Two men saying the same sentence: **I have become a narrow person and everything tires me.**

The first was in a job with a difficult manager over him. Tension every day, a tone in every message, and he came out of every meeting tight. Then it began coming down on the house: he came home dry with his wife, he slept badly, and he started saying of himself that he had changed.

The manager left the company. **In three weeks he was back as he had been**, without doing anything and without working on himself, **because the cause was taken away and the state went with it.**

The second was saying the same words exactly. He moved to another country, to quieter work, quieter people, more hours in the day.

Six months later he was saying the same sentence.

He was surprised himself. He had thought what narrowed him was the crowding and the work, **and he found the same narrowing in a place with neither.**

And the difference is not in the strength of either man. The first had a state passing over him, and had he spent six months treating it by its opposite he would have worn himself out for nothing. **The second has something living in him, and if he waits for it to leave on its own he will wait his whole life.**

And why the distinction matters this much

For two reasons, both practical.

The first is that the treatment differs. A state is carried, not treated, and what it mostly needs is sleep and food and quiet and days passing. A thing that lives in you is treated by its opposite over months. **A man who**

treated a state with the dose for a settled thing has wrecked himself, and a man who treated a settled thing with two days of patience thinks it has gone while it has not moved.

The second is that self flogging starts here. Because a man who calls every flat spell hardness, and every tight day a standing defect in his heart, spends his life putting himself on trial every week. And that on its own narrows a life more than the thing he was afraid of.

And this book does not diagnose you

And here is a part that has to be completely plain.

And whichever of the two men reads the map that follows while treating himself as the other one will get it wrong. Which is why you put the three distinctions above to a thing **before** you choose it to work on, and not after.

What is in this book is not a diagnosis, and cannot be one. If a doctor treated all his patients with one medicine he would destroy most of them. And you know yourself better than any page you are reading, and the page cannot see you and cannot hear the tone of your voice.

So take from the map what you know is you, and leave what you do not know. Everything you match yourself against here is a supposition you keep reviewing, not a verdict you sign.

And here is a limit where the book stops

If the weight has lasted for months, and one or more of these is with it:

- your sleep has gone, or you are sleeping far more than you used to
- your eating has changed, or your weight has moved and you did nothing to move it
- work or home has become too heavy to carry through the day
- your appetite for everything you used to love has gone
- a feeling has come that there is no use in any of it, or that your being here makes no difference

Then this is not the door of this book on its own. Keep the book, **and put a person beside it.**

And this is who to look for: a psychiatrist, or a therapist, or even the family doctor you see anyway, who can point you to one. In many countries there is a telephone line that answers on exactly this, **ask about it or look it up**, and there is no paperwork and no record and nobody is told.

And this is not a failure in you or in your will. Nobody blames a man for looking for a medicine for his body, and this is the same.

The action

Dose	The act
Full	Take the heaviest thing you complain of in yourself and answer the three distinctions above, one by one
Half	Answer one question: does this thing follow you everywhere, or does it stay in one place?
Smallest	Write today's date and one word for your state, and look at the sheet in two weeks

The sign that you moved: a heavy night passes over you and you do not build a verdict on yourself out of it, you say instead: that was a night. **That alone widens more than you think.**

The twenty two, in plain words

In two lines

This is the map of what narrows a life. Twenty two, in six families, **and it is not a charge sheet**. These are descriptions of things that settle in a person and eat at his space while he is not paying attention. You will not find one definition here; in each one you will find how to see it in your day, and the act that lifts it.

Three rules before you read

The first: you will not find yourself in twenty two. You will find yourself in three or four, and among them one will be the mother and the rest branches of it. **What is wanted is one.**

The second: do not read it looking for the worst thing in you. Read it looking for the **most repeated** thing in you. This book works on the repeated and not on the rare, as the mirror chapter set out.

The third: this is a supposition you review, not a verdict you sign. You may read one and think it is you when it is not, and you may pass quickly over the one that is you because it has become your nature. **Which is why it is best read with someone who knows you and does not flatter you, if you have one.**

Family one · When the heart goes quiet

This is the quietest of the families and the most dangerous, because it produces no pain to call you back. Nothing in it hurts, and everything in it subtracts.

1 · The day passes and you are not in it

You reach the evening unable to say what was in it. You walk into a room and cannot remember why. You close the screen and ask yourself what you were even looking at

The opposite, as an act

One silent minute tied to something that already happens in your day, not to a time on the clock

2 · Nothing reaches you any more

You hear of a death and finish your meal. What used to shake you passes and does not shake you. No tears, no reaction, no fear

The opposite, as an act

Cutting your surplus talk for one day, and getting close to one person who needs you, close enough to see him with your eyes

3 · The cold after the heat

You started something strongly and then it thinned, for no reason except that it thinned. The work still stands and there is no life in it

The opposite, as an act

Lower the dose and do not stop. This is not a settled thing, it is a passing state, and it has a whole chapter coming

4 · “There is still time”

You put off what you know matters because the life ahead looks long. You buy for ten years and do not act for one day

The opposite, as an act

Remembering that a life runs out. Once a week, one minute, with no panic and no lecture. **And if that thought comes to you anyway without being called, or it hurts, leave this one and take another**

The first of this family is its mother. Whoever works on being present in his day finds the other three lighten with it.

Family two · When you go back to the same thing

5 · I keep going back to it

You decide sincerely to stop, and then you go back, so you despair of your own decisions. The heaviest part is not the act, it is what it leaves behind, a weight that blocks you from every good thing

The opposite, as an act

Training yourself in the opposite until it becomes a habit, not one single effort.
And changing the place, if the place is what sets you off

6 · What pulls me is stronger than me

You know the thing harms you and you walk toward it with your eyes open. And it increases when you are full, and when you are idle, and when you are tired

The opposite, as an act

Not reaching for food unless you are hungry, and stopping before you are full. Then work that fills the empty space you fall into

7 · “This is just how I am”

You do not try at all, not because you do not want to, but because you have passed a final sentence on yourself

The opposite, as an act

You do not have the authority to pass a final sentence on yourself, and nobody else does either. A man who came back and regretted it has come back, he has not relapsed

The third is the most dangerous, because it is the one that seats you. Nothing said about the first two reaches a man who has been hit by it.

Family three · When you rise above people

8 · I am above these people

Sitting with people you consider beneath you is uncomfortable. And you turn down advice because of who gave it

The opposite, as an act

Sit through one sitting without speaking. And ask yourself: what am I above him in? Learning, money, family, strength?

9 · The pleasure that costs you

You are pleased with your own work without comparing yourself to anyone. So you see it as coming from yourself, not as something that came to you

The opposite, as an act

Count who helped you in that work, by name. **You will find the list longer than you thought**

10 · Wanting a place in people's minds

You arrange what you say so that it will be repeated. You choose work according to who will see it. This is the root the next one grows out of

The opposite, as an act

Do one good thing this week that nobody will ever know about

11 · Waiting and not doing

You reassure yourself while you have done nothing. You say “it will work out” in the exact spot where getting up was what was wanted

The opposite, as an act

The difference is one question: did you ask for what you are hoping for? If you asked, it is hope. If you left the work and waited, it is something else

Family four · When what you do for yourself rots from inside

12 · I work when someone is watching

Your work improves when it is seen, and your manners improve in front of the people who matter to you, and you straighten up when you sense someone looking. Its measure is one question: **if you were alone, would you do it?**

The opposite, as an act

One good thing nobody knows about. And know that a passing pleasure at praise that happened does not cancel what you did

13 · The checking that never ends

You open the message you sent and read it back ten times, you go back over a decision that is closed, and you inspect what moved you until you cannot act at all

The opposite, as an act

Finish the work and do not stop. The stopping is the illness, not the cure. One answer to the question, and then it is not repeated

And there is a relation between these two that has to be known: many people who think they have the first have the second. A man asking himself at every movement “am I doing this for people?” until he is paralysed is not doing it for people, **he has fallen into the checking itself.** The difference is that the first works for the eyes of others quietly, and the second suffers and does not work.

Family five · When it goes wrong between you and people

This is the widest family, and the one that shows most in an ordinary day.

14 · What he has bothers me

You wish something good would leave someone. Or you are glad when he stumbles. Or news of his success sits heavy on you

The opposite, as an act

Wish him well by name, and mention his good qualities in front of someone who knows him. **Do the opposite of what you find in yourself**

15 · I blow up and regret it

Your voice rises at the person who cannot answer back. Then you apologise, then you do it again

The opposite, as an act

Change your position in the same moment, leave the screen, and delay the reply by an hour. Anger is weakness, not strength

16 · I go quiet and keep it

You do not blow up, you keep it. So the dealings cool and the distance grows without anything having happened

The opposite, as an act

Deal with it at the anger itself, before it sets. **A grudge is anger that never came out and hardened**

17 · My tongue gets ahead of me

You carry talk about the absent, and you argue to win rather than to understand, and you promise without meaning it

The opposite, as an act

One hour of silence a day. And one question before any heated argument: **do I want him to understand, or do I want to beat him?**

18 · My eye on what is in someone else's hand

You press people for things, and you always measure yourself against whoever is above you in money

The opposite, as an act

Cut off asking people for a week. The hand works and the heart is not attached to what it works for

19 · I read everything the worst way

You read a short message and build a hostility on it. You read your friend's silence as a snub

The opposite, as an act

Find him one face other than the one that occurred to you, and think well of him once. **This does not mean denying a wrong that actually happened**

Family six · When it goes wrong between you and what you own and what happens to you

20 · Attached to a thing I would go with if it went

The problem is not that you own, the problem is that you cannot picture yourself without this thing. **The load you gathered out of love for it is the same load that torments you when you lose it**

The opposite, as an act

One question on every pursuit: **is this covering a need, or is it piling up?** Only surplus for the pile is what is spoken against, not the pursuit itself

21 · I give and it hurts

You give while something in you pulls against it, so you come away irritated. **A man who gives while something in him pulls against it is forcing himself, he is not generous**

The opposite, as an act

Give with the forcing until the heart settles. **The measure is your gladness, not the amount**

22 · I cannot accept what happened

You object to what cannot be returned, so you add a second calamity to the first

The opposite, as an act

Accept it and work on it at the same time, there is no contradiction. And know that the hardest hours of an affliction are the hours it happens in, and everything after is lighter

Four distinctions that stop a common mistake

What gets mixed up	The difference, in one question
I am above them · and the pleasure that costs you	Do you need another person present to feel it? If yes it is the first, if no it is the second
The cold after the heat · and “this is just how I am”	Are you still doing something, however little? If yes it is a passing coldness, if you have stopped and sentenced yourself it is the second
Waiting without working · and hope	Did you ask for what you are hoping for?
What he has bothers me · and competing	Do you want it to leave him, or do you want the like of it for yourself?

The action

One. Not two.

Dose	The act
Full	Choose one, write under it three situations that actually happened to you this month, then write its opposite in the form of an act
Half	Choose one and write one situation under it
Smallest	Put a mark next to one, and write nothing

The sign that you moved: a moment passes in your week when you say “this is it” while you are inside it, not after it is over. **Whoever saw it while he was in it has covered half the road.**

Every ailment is treated by its opposite, and the root is love

In two lines

Half the map you saw in the last chapter is what narrows. **This chapter is its other half: what widens.** A man who works by expulsion alone spends his life in a chase, and a man who knows the opposite is at rest, because one spot will not hold both.

Why stopping is not enough

Try deciding not to think of one particular thing for one minute. You will find yourself thinking of nothing else.

A person does not empty, he gets occupied. A man who stopped himself being angry and put nothing in its place got the anger back in another form: a heavy silence, or a cold sentence that cuts deeper than shouting. A man who stopped himself looking and did not occupy his heart with anything larger got it back on the first tiring night.

So the rule is: **do not only stop, put its opposite in the place.**

A man who decided to be glad for a colleague

A man at work, and a colleague younger than him moved to a better post.

He thinks of himself as a decent man, so he decided to lift what was in him and be glad. **He kept telling himself: he deserves it, the world is wide, everyone has his share.** He repeated it for a week.

After the week, the first time the colleague came up, he heard himself say a small sentence with a barb in it. **Not a lie, but the sentence made the thing a little smaller.** He felt tight afterwards, and added blame on top, **and came out of the week with the tightness doubled: at his colleague, and at himself for not managing it.**

The mistake was that he ordered his heart, and a heart takes no orders.

Then he did something else entirely, with no leaning toward it: **he said one good thing about the man, by name, in front of someone who knew him.** One true sentence about work he did think good.

He said it while he was put out. **And that is exactly what was wanted.** He came away feeling nothing, **and thinking it had not worked.**

He did it again a week later, and a third time a fortnight after that.

In the second month the colleague's name passed over him plainly. Not because he had fought himself, **but because his interior had shifted under acts his tongue said while he did not believe them.**

The tongue in front, and the heart catching up. Not the other way.

And the opposite is an act, not a feeling

And the table below is not a repeat of the one in the last chapter. That one told you **what** the opposite is. This one tells you **how it gets done:** in which moment, in front of whom, and how you know you have done it.

This is the most important thing in the chapter.

A man who says “the cure for what I feel about what he has is to be happy for him” has described the outcome and prescribed it as the medicine. **A feeling cannot be commanded, an act can.** Which is why the opposite is always something you do with your hand or your tongue, even if you find no leaning toward it in your heart.

If what narrows you is	Then its opposite is an act of this kind
Discomfort at what someone else has	Wishing him well by name, or mentioning his good qualities in front of someone who knows him
Wanting to be seen	Doing one good thing nobody will ever know about
Hardness	Getting close to one person who needs you, close enough to see him with your eyes, not reading about compassion
Attachment to what other people hold	Counting what is in your own hands, one by one, by name, not in a lump
Quick anger	Changing your position in the same moment, and delaying the reply by an hour

And what is wanted is not that you feel its effect on the day you do it. What is wanted is that you repeat it. The heart follows the act after a while, as the dust settled from the act before.

And the root everything wide branches from

If you gathered everything that widens a life and traced it back to one root, it would come back to one thing: **that there is something in your heart larger than you which you love.**

A man whose heart has filled with a large love finds the things that used to move him have shrunk, not because he fought them, but because they no longer weigh what they used to weigh with him. **That is the difference between a man stopping himself and coming apart, and a man who no longer finds any taste in the thing he is abstaining from.**

And this book does not tell you what that larger thing is. That is your answer, from wherever you came by it. What it says is that a man with nothing larger than himself that he loves is trying to lift the whole narrowing with his own hands, and his hands will not lift it.

And from that root four things branch, and you will see their trace in the two remaining parts:

Accepting after you have tried, which is accepting what fell after you spent what you could. It does not mean leaving off the trying; the trying comes first and the accepting comes after it, not before. **Seeing what you have while you are still in it,** not after it has gone. **Staying in the right place while the thing is heavy. Doing well the work nobody can see.**

And why these become acts that can be seen

Someone may say: this is fine talk, so how will I know I have got there?

The answer is that all of these have a visible form that people can see. Forbearance is seen in the tone of your voice when the person under your hand makes a mistake. Compassion is seen in how much of your time you give to someone who can do nothing for you. Humility is seen in who you sit with when nobody is watching. **What has no form in an act that can be noticed is an easy claim to make.**

Which is why the measure of progress in this book has always been an act that can be seen, not a feeling that can be described.

The action

Go back to the thing you chose in the last chapter, and bring out one opposite for it on the condition above: **an act you do with your hand or your tongue, not a feeling you wait for.**

Dose	The act
Full	Do the opposite three times this week, and hang it on something that already happens in your day
Half	Once this week
Smallest	Write the opposite in one line, in the form of an act and not in the form of a quality

The sign that you moved: you find no leaning toward it in your heart, and then you do it. **That particular time is the one that leaves the mark, not the ones you did while you wanted to.**

Eight acts have passed. Still **one**. The map is not a list to work through, it is something you look for yourself in and leave the rest.

PART THREE

The four circles

Yourself, your home, your work, your people. The circle
widens from the centre.

Yourself

In two lines

The first circle, and everything after it stands on it. **One thing is wanted from it: a rhythm that keeps standing without enthusiasm.** Not that you become more active, but that the thing stays standing in the week when you find no leaning toward it at all.

Four hours, and then the whole day

A woman slept four and a half hours. Not because she was up over anything worth it, but because she lay turning the screen over, too tired to put it down.

She woke twenty minutes late and drank her tea standing. She reached the ward with her head at half its speed, so she took the easy things first: the handover, the notes, the list. **The heavy thing she had come in early for waited until the end, and the end came when she was more tired.**

At three she was sharp with a colleague over a word that did not deserve it, then spent three minutes explaining herself and came out worse.

At six she was suddenly hungry, ate standing up, and afterwards there was a heaviness in her chest that she put down to a hard day.

She got home and her daughter ran at her, and she felt the weight of it, and gave her the tablet to keep her quiet. After the girl was asleep she lay

blaming herself for giving her daughter no time.

Two days on she asked what had made her so sharp that week. She looked in her temper, in the pressure at work, in the people at home. **She did not look at the sleep.**

And if anyone had told her it was the sleep, she would have said that is far too small a thing for a problem like this. **And that is the thing. What looks smaller than the problem is what holds it up from underneath.**

Why you start here

Because you walk into your home and your work and your people carrying what is in you, not what you intended for them.

A man who has not slept has become less able to bear his son, and he does not have a parenting problem. A man whose stomach is loaded has become slower toward every good thing, and he does not have a motivation problem. **Most of what gets counted as a problem of character is at root a problem of body and time.**

And there is a line that has to be said this plainly:

You are selling your health and your time every day for a worthless price, and thinking you are ahead.

You are not losing them out of ignorance, you are selling them in a transaction you consider a gain, until enough years pass and you look at

the ledger.

The fault in most people

It is not that they do not want. They want in one night what would be enough for a year.

A man decides in one night that he will sleep early, and get up early, and walk for half an hour, and leave the screen, and read. Then he wakes tomorrow having done one of five, so he counts himself a failure, so he drops all five by the third week.

The cure is not that he increases his will, it is that he reduces what he asks of himself until it is something that cannot fall.

One hung it on a clock, and one hung it on a key

Two people decided the same thing in the same week: ten minutes of walking every day.

The first set an alarm for seven. The first morning he got up and walked. The second morning it rang while he was washing, so he silenced it and said he would go at night, and did not. The third morning he silenced it without noticing. The fourth he did not hear it. After two weeks he deleted it, **and wrote a new line in his head about himself.**

The second set no alarm. She lives three floors up in a block with no lift, and she said: the moment I put the key in the street door, I walk once round the block before I go up.

And it happened, because she comes to that door every day whether she wants to or not. **A clock calls you, and an event catches you.**

In the third week came a day she was worn through. She stood two seconds at the door, walked to the corner and came back. A minute and a half. **That is not a failure, that is the same thing smaller.**

In the sixth week she came home on the phone and found her feet going the same way with no decision in it. **That is the first sign a thing has come down out of your head into your day.**

Three months on she was still walking. Not because her will was stronger, **but because she had tied it to something that does not need her to remember it.**

One rule for this circle

One small thing, hung on something that already happens, that keeps standing for thirteen weeks. And the thirteen are not a condition of entry, they are **the shortest run in which a thing comes down out of your head into your day.** After that you are free: carry on with it, or leave it and take another, **and the sheet is the same either way.**

Do not hang it on a time on your phone, because the time passes over you and then you silence it. Hang it on something that happens in your day anyway: after you wash your face, after the last meal of the day, before you open the laptop, the moment you park the car outside the house.

And you choose the thing it hangs on, from your day. What worked for someone else will not work for you, because his day is not your day.

And when you fall

You will fall. And that is ordinary.

The rule is that you lower the dose and do not stop. A man who was walking thirty minutes and got tired walks five, and does not drop it. A man who was reading a page and found it heavy reads a line. **Because what we are building is not the thirty minutes, it is that you do not break off.**

And a man who walked for a month and then stopped for a week has not gone back to the starting point. That is a belief with no ground under it, and it causes more despair than the break itself.

The action for this circle

Dose	The act
Full	Choose one act in your body or your time, hang it on something fixed in your day, and write them together in one line
Half	The same act, half the amount
Smallest	The smallest version of the same act, not an easier different act. If you chose walking, the smallest is to walk for one minute, not to read about walking

The sign that you moved: a week passes over you in which you find no enthusiasm, and you do it in that week. **The week without enthusiasm is the only one that measures anything.**

Your home

In two lines

The second circle, and what is wanted from it is **presence, not mere attendance**. You are at home for hours every day, and the question is not how long you sat, but how much of you was left there.

Ninety minutes, and his son remembers he was not there

Half eight in the evening. He is on the sofa, the television on, his son on the floor playing.

His son said, Dad, look. He said, yes, love. A minute later, Dad, look. He said, I can see, I can see. A while later the boy came and stood right in front of the phone, and he moved him gently aside and said, one second.

At ten the boy went to sleep. And the father sat working it out: an hour and a half. More than yesterday, and more than most men he knows.

And if you asked the boy a week later, does your dad sit with you, he would say, not much.

Both are telling the truth. He did sit for an hour and a half, and he was not there. **The time was paid and did not arrive, like money into the wrong account.**

And it tires both. The father got up with nothing rested in him, because he was neither at work nor with them. The boy got up still wanting what he

did not get, so he pushes harder, so the father gets heavier. **So it goes round, and nobody won.**

In your grandfather's house this did not exist. He was there or he was not. **There was no such thing as sitting with them and not being with them,** because he carried nothing that could take him out of the room.

You are the first generation that can be absent while present. And that is what needs a decision, not the time.

Being present and absent at the same time

This is the commonest thing in households now, and it did not exist one generation ago.

You sit with them in the same room for two hours. Your eye is on a screen, your ear catches half of what is said, and you reply with the right words in the right places. **And if the person with you were asked “was he with you?” he would hesitate.** Then you go to sleep counting that you gave two hours, and they are counting that you were not there.

And the strange part is that this is more tiring than being fully present, because you paid the time and took nothing back for it, and neither did they.

And the rule here is not quantity

Ten present minutes weigh more than two absent hours. And that is a relief, because time is the thing you do not own enough of to give, and presence is yours.

And the trace of presence shows in one thing: **the person with you starts telling you small things.** Large things get told to anyone; small things only get told to someone who listens.

The tone you keep for the one who cannot answer back

A woman teaches. Everyone around her says she is patient, and that is not flattery, it is true.

In the classroom, when a child gets something wrong, she says it gently and explains again. With the friend who turns up half an hour late she laughs and says it is nothing. With someone older than her she stays quiet even when she is in the right.

And in the house, when her mother asks her the same question for the third time, her voice changes. When her boy of seven calls her for the fourth time in ten minutes, she answers with one flat word. When her mother starts the story she has heard twenty times, she says, I know, you have told me.

And she does not notice. **And not one of them will hold her to account, and not one of them will tell anybody.**

And that is exactly what makes them the scale. How you deal with someone you need is not news about you, it is news about your need. **What comes out of you with the one you need nothing from is you.**

And the small authority in the house is not less than the one at work, it is more dangerous. The one who works with you can leave, and your child will not. He will stand in front of you and take the sound of your voice

and put it inside, **and bring it out in twenty years on somebody else, not knowing where it came from.**

And the people under your hand have the first claim on you

At home the truest part of you shows, because at home is the person who cannot answer you back: a small child, an elderly father, someone who works for you.

Each of us is responsible for whoever is under his hand, and responsibility is not spending alone.

Responsibility is that your presence in the life of the person under your hand is good for him, not something he endures. A man who wants to know his real character should look at the tone of his voice when someone who cannot hold him to account makes a mistake in front of him.

And what ruins households is something small

It is not the large quarrel. The large quarrel happens once a year and gets dealt with.

What ruins is the small and repeated: the flat reply when you are tired, the small promise made to a child and forgotten, the remark made in front of other people, the silence that stretches after a row to a day and then two. **Things like that never get apologised for, because they are smaller than an apology, so they settle the way dust settles.**

The action for this circle

Dose	The act
Full	Fifteen minutes daily, hung on something fixed, with the phone in another room and not in your pocket. And in it you fix nothing and advise nothing, you only listen
Half	Five minutes on the same condition
Smallest	One question you ask, and then you are quiet until the answer is finished, however long it takes

The sign that you moved: they start the talking before you ask. That is a sign that cannot be manufactured, so wait for it and do not rush it.

Your work

In two lines

The third circle, and two things are wanted from it: **work that does not eat the rest of your life, and a small authority that is merciful.** Most people treat the first and are not paying attention to the second, and the second is more dangerous and reaches further.

Eleven forty

Eleven forty at night. He put the phone down and turned off the light.

A message came. The light of the screen struck the ceiling. He reached over to see who it was, with no intention of replying. Work, and a question that needed two lines.

He said to himself: two lines and I sleep.

He wrote the two lines. Then he saw his answer would open a second question tomorrow, so he decided to settle it now. Then he opened the file to check a figure. Then he found a small mistake in it and corrected it. Then he looked at the clock and it was twenty to one.

He slept. At three he woke remembering something else missing from the file, and lay half an hour deciding whether to get up or wait for morning.

And the question is not why he replied at eleven forty.

The question is why it cost him less to answer than to lie there holding a question he had left. Answering ends the tension in thirty seconds, **and the one who leaves it carries it until morning.** And carrying it is real tiredness.

So he is not working at night, **he is escaping a feeling.** And work done to escape a feeling is not work, **it is a painkiller.**

In the morning he said what he says every time: **I just cannot find the time.**

And he finds it. **He gives it to something he never decided, because nobody told him no, and he does not know how to tell himself no.**

When work goes past its limit

Your grandfather's work had a door that shut.

And an open door is not the one you hold open, it is the one somebody walks through. If nobody has walked through your door in six months, **then the door is shut and you cannot see it.** Your work has no door.

The messages reach your bed, the meeting can happen from anywhere, and the question arrives on your holiday and you answer because answering is easier than bearing the fact that you did not. So nothing in your life is left called "after work," **and work becomes the life and everything else becomes crumbs that fall off it.**

And this is not treated with intentions. It is treated with one clear limit that you know and the people working with you know, **a small limit you**

keep and do not break, which is better than a large limit you announce and then undo on the first night.

And earning a living, and piling up, are two different things

Working for a living is not something to be blamed for; it is necessary. And the problem is not working long hours in a season that deserves it.

The problem is working to have more rather than to have enough. And one distinction separates them, a question you put to every increase: **is this covering a need, or is it piling up?** The first is earning, and the second is what eats your years while you count it as prudence.

A woman who was afraid to say she had got it wrong

A woman on a small team ordered the stock for the shop and keyed in the wrong quantity. **A mistake that would have taken five minutes to undo if it had been said the same hour.**

She spent two days working out how to say it. Every day she pictured her manager's face while he listened, the two seconds he would stay quiet before answering, and the sentence he would say in front of the others.

On the third day the pallets came in, and the window for sending them back had closed.

And the mistake became four times bigger. Not because it grew, but because it was late. And something came with it: the whole team saw that the one who gets it wrong gets found out from outside.

And the manager did not shout at anybody. If you asked him he would say, my door is open, and I am the first to say when I am wrong.

Only, when somebody got something wrong, he would stay quiet two seconds before answering. And he would say “Right” in a certain way. And he would ask “how did that happen?” in that tone and not another one.

Three small things, not one of them anything a person could be held to account for, and together they taught the team that mistakes get hidden.

And that is dust settling, by the law in the chapter on the mirror. **There is no one moment you can point at and say, it started here. And it happened all the same.**

And the small authority

The most dangerous thing in this circle is that you hold something over somebody. Even if you do not think of yourself as holding any power at all.

The person who works under you, the person waiting for your signature, the person who needs you to reply so he can sleep easy, the person afraid to tell you he got something wrong: all of these are under your hand. **Authority does not corrupt a man, it exposes him.** Because it lifts from him the need to please, and what the need was covering shows.

The best person you can hire is the one who is both capable and trustworthy, and neither one stands in for the other.

A man who was capable and not trusted did harm, and a man who was trusted and not capable wasted what he was given. That is a scale you weigh yourself with before you weigh anyone who works with you.

And the cheapest act in this circle

Doing well a piece of work nobody can see.

Because doing well what is seen is shared between you and the love of being seen, and you cannot tell which of the two moved you. **Doing well what is never seen at all is yours alone, and it builds something inside you and not in your reputation.**

The action for this circle

Dose	The act
Full	One daily limit you announce to the people you work with and keep for a week, and one piece of careful work nobody knows about
Half	The limit on its own, even if it is half an hour at the end of the night
Smallest	Not replying to one work message after an hour you choose tonight. One only

The sign that you moved: the person who works with you tells you about a mistake he made before you discover it. **A man who is safe with you is honest with you, and nothing measures a small authority more truthfully than that.**

Your people

In two lines

The fourth and last circle, and what is wanted from it is **a circle with people in it, not contacts**. You know several times more people today than your grandfather knew, **and none of them knows you**, and that is the narrowing itself.

Nine hundred people, and one

A man opened his phone and found nine hundred numbers in it.

He had been away a month for the work, in a let room near the site. The first week he was busy. The second week he sat alone one night after a heavy day, **and said: I will call somebody**.

He went down the list from the top.

That one is a colleague, and the talk will be work, and he does not want to talk about work. That one is his cousin, and he must ask after the whole family first, and then she will ask if he is all right, and he will say he is. That one is a friend from school, last spoken to two years ago, so the call will start with “you have been missed” and end in three minutes, and he needs thirty.

He put the phone down and called nobody. And watched something until he fell asleep.

He is not alone. He has nine hundred people, and eight would take a train to him if he asked. The night is about there being none of them for a night like that one. One you can call with no opening and no reason and say, I am worn out today, without saying why, and without fear he will call it weakness.

When he came back, the first thing he was asked was, what did you get done out there? **He said, a lot of work.**

And that was true, and it was not the answer.

Knowing many and being known by nobody

Open your phone and count who you could call right now. You will find hundreds, perhaps thousands.

Then ask three more questions: **who knows my fault and will say it to me?** And who, if I were gone a month, would ask after me, not because he saw my absence on a screen, but because he missed me? And who could I show the part I do not put on a screen?

You will find the answer a very small number, and perhaps you will not find one.

That is the difference: the knowing is plenty, and the connection is scarce. What answers a person's need is the second, and the first does not answer it even if it runs into millions.

One friendship lived by repetition, and one died with its reason

A man has two friends from the years the three of them shared a flat. Then they went to three different cities.

The first calls him once every two months, and every call has a reason: an occasion, or congratulations, or a question. The call is genuinely good, and at the end they say we should talk more, and hang up pleased. **And after a few years they knew nothing about each other but the headings: he moved, he married, he had a child.**

The second sends him something small every few days for no reason. A photograph, or a line he heard, or “have you seen this?” **And most of it gets no reply.** Sometimes a fortnight passes with nothing, and then it comes back with no apology and no “you have been missed.”

In the year the ground went out from under him, the one who called was the second. **With nobody telling him.** He did not know anything had happened, **he was only near enough for the sound to reach him.**

And the difference is not in the love. Both love him, and if they knew they would stand with him. **The difference is that one is building a line that works, and one is building a memory.**

And the line gets built by one thing: repetition with no purpose. It is the cheapest thing in this circle, **and the only thing with no reason pushing you toward it.**

And connection is the one part of your life that dies if you give it a reason.

And why this in particular got narrow

Because connection needs two things your time does not like: **unbroken hours, and repetition for no reason.**

Friendship is not built in one long sitting, it is built in many short sittings with no purpose. And today you meet nobody except by appointment and for a reason. **And a man you only meet for a reason has nothing left between you when the reason is finished.**

And you become like whoever you sit with

Look at any room you sit in for two hours: **you come out of it at its temperature.** If it was hot you are sweating, if it was cold you are shivering, and you decided nothing, and the room intended nothing for you.

So the effect lands with no intent on either side. And that is what makes sitting more dangerous than advice: advice you hear and judge, and the temperature you take while nobody asked you.

And the people you sit with today are not only the ones you sit with. **Whoever is in your ear every day, whoever you read every morning, whoever's life you follow while he does not know you, all of these are people you sit with.** And they do to you what the room does, without your having chosen them.

And a limit not to cross

And here is a place where a heavy mistake happens.

A man who reads this chapter starts sorting people by how useful they are to him, bringing the useful near and pushing the useless away. **That is the scale of a trade, not the scale of a brotherhood.** People are not resources to be managed, and a man who treats his friends this way has narrowed his life in a new way while thinking he has organised it.

And the right company is known by its trace in one thing: **that you come away from them nearer to what you would like to be, not that you come away having gained something.**

The action for this circle

Dose	The act
Full	One sitting a week with no reason. No business, no occasion, no subject
Half	One call a week to the person you only ever call about something
Smallest	One message in which you ask for nothing and reply to nothing

The sign that you moved: someone calls you for no reason. **What you start comes back to you, and this circle alone of the four shows its trace from outside you and not from inside you.**

Twelve acts have passed you, and still **one** is running. The next part is the one that tells you how that act is written so it lasts.

PART FOUR

How to walk

The day, the week, the year, what you do when you stop,
and how you leave.

The day · one act, three doses

In two lines

This is the first skill in the book, and if you came out of it with nothing else you would have taken most of it. **That you can write yourself an act that can actually be done.** Most of what falls from people's intentions does not fall out of weakness in them, it falls because it was written in a form that cannot be done at all.

Your day is three steps

Where you are · what you do · how you know you moved. There is no fourth.

The first is a short look at your state today, with no analysis. The second is one act. The third is a sign you know you have taken a step by, so that you do not walk for a month without knowing where you are in it.

Two lines on a phone, and only one of them happened

A man wrote this in the notes on his phone on the first night of the year:

“Be closer to my family, look after my health, cut down the screen.”

All of it is true. **And still there is nothing in it that can be done tomorrow at nine.**

“Be closer” is not an act, it is a result. “Look after my health” is not an act, it is an intention. “Cut down the screen” is an act, but with no how much in it, no when, and no way of knowing he has cut anything.

Three months later he opened the note, felt the narrowing, and closed it. **That is what a list like that does: it reminds you that you are not moving, and it does not tell you what to do.** So it costs you something every time you open it, **and buys you nothing.**

On the same phone, in another app, was a second line, written without his thinking it mattered:

“When I put the keys down, ask my daughter one question and stay quiet until she has finished.”

That line is the only one that happened. Not because it matters more than the three above it, **but because it can be done.**

There is a moment that comes every day without exception. There is one act. There is a measure, the staying quiet until she has finished. And somebody else notices.

What separates the two lines is not how much he meant them. It is the shape of the sentence.

How an act that can be done gets written

Four conditions. Whichever one is missing brings it down within a week:

The first: small enough to make you laugh. If you said “this is too small to be worth writing down,” you have got the size right. A person resists the large and does not resist what he thinks nothing of.

The second: hung on something that happens, not on a time. “After I put the keys on the table” is stronger than “at nine,” because the hour passes over you while you are in something else, and the event happens to you so you remember. **And choose the thing from your own day, not from a day you wish you had.**

The third: it has a sign you can touch. “Be better” is not a sign. “Sleep with the phone outside the room” is a sign.

The fourth: it takes shrinking. This is the finest of the conditions, and the one most plans fall on.

Shrinking by reducing, not by substituting

Every act has three doses: **full, half, and smallest.**

And the smallest is not a different, easier act. **It is the same act, smaller.**

The act	Correct shrinking	Wrong shrinking
Walk for thirty minutes	Walk for one minute	Read about the benefits of walking
Read a page quietly	Read one line	Listen to something while driving

The act	Correct shrinking	Wrong shrinking
Sit with my son for fifteen minutes	Sit with him two minutes with no phone	Buy him something

The difference is not in the effort, the difference is that the road stays one road. A man who walked one minute is walking, and he can add tomorrow. A man who read about walking has changed the road, and he will add nothing to it tomorrow.

The night the dose was bigger than the day

A woman wrote her act for the week: ten pages after the children are asleep.

Two nights she did it, sitting on the floor beside the mattress, in the light from the landing coming through the open door.

The third day was long. The little one was ill, and they went down late, and she sat with the book, read two lines, and fell asleep holding it.

The next night she said one sentence: **I do not follow through.** She put the book on the floor against the wall and did not open it. Nor the night after. The week that followed she read nothing.

And the real fall was not the long day.

On the long day she read two lines, **which is exactly what the day could carry.** And those two lines are good news: the thing stayed standing on the worst day of her week.

The fall was the night after, when she called the two lines failure.

Had there been two answers only, Done and Smaller, she would have said Smaller. The dose would have come down to one page, and she would have read a page the next night, and gone back to ten or not, **and nothing would have broken, because there was never a chain.**

A box called “did not do” measures nothing. It does not tell you what the dose was, or what the day held. **It teaches you to say a word about yourself.** And that word stays with you long after you forget what you were doing.

Two answers, not three

At the end of the day you have two answers: **Done**, and **Smaller**.

There is no button called “did not do,” and no box called “failed.” **Because what was not done is not a failure of yours, it is news about the dose: it was bigger than your day.** So you come down a step, and things carry on.

And if the whole day passed and you did nothing and said nothing, that is also not a failure. **It is the same answer in a clearer form: the dose is too big.**

And do not hold yourself to account for one day. The reckoning is for the week, and it is in the next chapter.

The action

Dose	The act
Full	Write your act for the week on the four conditions, with its three doses and its sign. In four lines
Half	Write the act and the thing it will hang on
Smallest	Write the thing it hangs on, on its own. Anything that happens in your day every day without exception

The sign that you moved: you find yourself doing it without having remembered it. **That alone is the difference between something you intend and something that has become part of your day.**

The week · five and one and open

In two lines

A day on its own is too small to be governed by, and a year is too large to hold. **The week is the unit a person is measured in.** This chapter gives you the shape of the week: five days of acting, one day of a question, one open day.

A verdict passed in the worst hour

A woman three weeks into something, and going well.

Her days off move with the rota, so no day is always hers. This week the long run fell badly. On one of those days she had slept five hours, a shift ran two hours over, a row came on the phone on the way home, and she got in late, **and did not do the act.**

At one in the morning she sat on the edge of the bed and said one sentence:

“I am not the sort of person these things work for.”

That sentence is not about that day. **It is a verdict on three weeks, passed in the worst hour of the worst of them.**

Had she looked at the whole week she would have found two days done, one smaller, one empty, one of a question. **A week with a single fall in it,** which is a good week by any reckoning.

But she did not look at the week. She looked at the last twenty four hours. And a day sees only itself, with no room in it for what came before.

A person who reckons by the day passes sentence thirty times a month, and one is bound to come like that. **And then the verdict gets believed, not because it is true, but because it was said at an hour when she could not answer.**

The week prevents this because it gathers. It puts your tired self and your rested self on one scale, **so no half of you judges the whole.**

Why the week in particular

Because it is longer than your mood and shorter than your life.

A man who reckons himself by the day has wronged himself, because one heavy day makes him pass a sentence on himself he does not deserve. **And a man who reckons by the month has forgotten,** because a month passes with two weeks in it he cannot recall.

And the week is wide enough for you to fall once inside it and still be standing. That is a merciful and an honest scale at the same time.

The five days

Five days in which the one act you wrote runs, at the dose your day can carry. Do not change the act mid week, even if you are bored of it. **Change the dose, not the act.**

The day of the question

One day in the week with no act in it, one question only. The strongest question about the thing you are working on, and you stop at it for a minute.

Its use is that it stops the act becoming a movement with no meaning. A man who walked for five weeks and never once asked himself what was happening in him is walking because he started, not because he wants to.

And the open day

One day in the week with nothing asked of it. No act, no question, no making up for what was missed.

And this is the hardest part of the shape on a person, because something in us wants to fill the empty with something, **and because everything built in your time was built on you not stopping.** Everything on your phone measures an unbroken run for you, and frightens you about breaking it, and builds into you a fear of interruption.

And this book hands you the interruption itself, so that you stop being afraid of it.

And why by rule, not by mood

And here is the most important line in the chapter, the one that separates a real open day from one you wish for every week and never get:

A rule you set once is stronger than a decision you take every week, because the decision is the thing that fails.

A man waiting every week to see whether he is up to it never stops, because he is entering the same fight four times a month and losing it. **A man who made the day a rule and gave it a name and told the people around him “that day is closed” is not negotiating with himself at all.**

And there is a second difference, and it is the large practical one: **a man who leaves his work for a day because he decided to, keeps his mind in the work.** He looks at the phone once, and answers one message, and tells himself “this is not work, this is just clearing.” **A man who leaves it because that is what the rule says actually comes out of it,** because he has nothing to bargain with.

And every people that lasted invented itself a day it stopped on by rule, long before anyone was measuring productivity or writing about the management of time. The thing is older than our ability to explain it, **and we are the first generation to remove it and then go looking for a substitute in an app.**

The first open day

The first man to try a real open day spent it watching the clock.

Ten in the morning: he told himself he was comfortable. Eleven: he opened the phone “just to see.” Twelve: he read a work message and did not answer it, and stayed busy with it half an hour, working out what to say tomorrow. One: he tidied a cupboard, and said that this is not work.

At three in the afternoon a heavy feeling came that he could not name. Not boredom. Closer to a feeling that he was stealing something. **And what he was stealing was not anyone’s time. It was his own sense that he was useful.**

At four he opened the laptop and said the sentence that ends every open day: **I will just finish one small thing so tomorrow is lighter.** And worked two hours.

That night he was tired, and not pleased, and not rested. **He paid for the day and took nothing for it.**

The next open day was easier, because he knew three in the afternoon was coming. The one after that he read something useless for four hours. The one after that he felt nothing at all, which was the strangest of them.

And that is the ordinary course of it, not a sign of a fault in you. You were trained for years that stopping is wrong, that the empty must be filled, that whoever is not producing is losing. **That training does not come undone in one day. It comes undone in three.**

And it is closed and then opened, not empty

And this day is two halves, not one.

Its first half is closed: the work is shut, the messages stay shut, and nothing missed in the week is made up. **Its second half is opened:** you spread out into something else entirely. People, or walking, or eating slowly, or nothing, but nothing by your own will.

That is why we called it the open day and not the empty day. The empty weighs on you and returns you to the screen within two hours. The open makes room for you.

And the day itself is a variable, not a fixed thing. Every country and every kind of work has its own: some countries stop on a Friday, some on a Saturday, some on a Sunday, and whoever's work takes that day from him chooses another. **The shape is one and the name changes.** What matters is that you name it, and tell at least one person, and do not move it every week.

The week sheet

And all of it gathers on one sheet you fill in every week, fifty two times. It lives in the app, and it is explained at the end of the book. On it:

Where I am now, which of the four circles · **what I am working on**, a word or two · **what it hangs on** · **the three doses** · **the sign** · **and seven small boxes**, day by day.

And the boxes are a counter, not a chain. What has passed is not cancelled if one of them breaks, and there is no box in it for failure.

The action

Dose	The act
Full	Fill the week sheet completely, name your open day, and tell one person
Half	Fill the first two lines: where you are, and what you are working on
Smallest	Name your open day and nothing else

The sign that you moved: the open day passes over you and you do not feel you have fallen short in it. **The first time you will feel it. By the third you will not, and that is the sign.**

When you stop

In two lines

You will stop. That is not a possibility, it is news, **and this book was not built for someone who does not stop, it was built for someone who stops and comes back.** This chapter gives you what to do on that particular night.

And there is a stop of another kind, and it is not the one this chapter is about: if you have been stopped for months, and with it your sleep has gone, or your appetite for everything has gone, or a feeling has come that there is no use in any of it · **then that is not a stop of the dose, and this is not the door of this book on its own.** Go back to the end of chapter six and do what is written there. **And it is not a failure in you.**

And there is a stop of another kind, and it is not the one this chapter is about: if you have been stopped for months, and with it your sleep has gone, or your appetite for everything has gone, or a feeling has come that there is no use in any of it · **then that is not a stop of the dose, and this is not the door of this book on its own.** Go back to the end of chapter six and do what is written there. **And it is not a failure in you.**

Two weeks with the act standing and the heart absent

A woman had been walking twenty minutes after work for five months, and had not missed a day.

Then two strange weeks came. She was doing it, and finishing it, **and feeling nothing.** No ease, no narrowing, not even boredom. Like somebody signing a form.

So she went looking for a cause. She went over her sleep, and her eating, and what she might have got wrong lately, and searched herself every night before she slept. **And found nothing. Because there was nothing.**

Then she began to explain it larger. Perhaps this thing does not suit me. Perhaps I have changed. Perhaps that was the enthusiasm of the beginning, and it is spent.

After two weeks she said: perhaps this thing has finished with me. And she stopped.

A month and a half later she sat one night feeling narrow, and said she ought to start something like what she used to do. **And she went looking for it from the beginning, as though the five months had not happened.**

The mistake was not that she went cold. The cold comes to anybody who does a thing steadily, and often there is no reason beyond that it came. And it passes as it came.

The mistake was that she treated the cold as a verdict. She took a state that was passing and read it as a final answer about herself and what she was doing. **And a state cannot answer that question, because it can see nothing but the two weeks it is standing in.**

A heavy day or a cold spell

These are two different things, and most people mix them and treat each with the other's medicine.

A heavy day is a day you slept little, or news reached you, or you tired in a way you can see. Its cure is that it passes. And no verdict is built on it.

A cold spell is two weeks passing while you do the same thing and there is no life in it. Nothing happened, there is no visible cause, the act stands and the heart is absent.

And one question tells them apart: **is it the act that broke off, or the leaning?** If the leaning broke off and the act still stands, that is a cold spell, and it is not a settled thing and not a punishment, **and it hits everyone who ever did anything steadily, and it has hit people better than us.**

And the cure is lowering the dose, not stopping

This is the most important line in the chapter.

A man whose appetite for thirty minutes went cold, and who then walked five, has stayed on the road until his appetite comes back. A man who stopped altogether waiting for the enthusiasm to return **is waiting for something that does not come back by waiting.** The leaning follows the act and not the other way round, and this happens every time.

And the smallest thing you do in a cold spell is better than the greatest thing you intend in it.

The night everything is decided

The night you stop is not the night you feel something. **It is a completely ordinary night, and you will not remember it.**

A day passed over a man and he did not do the thing, and he slept. Nothing in that. The next day the same. Nothing in that either, and there was a reason besides. The third day he thought of it in the morning, said he would do it at night, and forgot.

On the fourth day the real thing happened: he thought of it, and felt a small discomfort, and changed the subject in his own head in two seconds.

That is it. **Not the break. The moment you decide not to look.**

Because after that, every time it comes to mind the discomfort comes with it, and every time it does you change the subject faster. **And after two weeks it is a thing you avoid, not a thing you stopped.**

And there is a wide difference between the two. A man who stopped a thing can go back any day. **A man who has begun to avoid it pays a small price every time he remembers, so he teaches himself not to remember.**

Nothing took it from him. He put it down himself, in two seconds, with nobody in the room.

And what separates the one who comes back from the one who does not is that he looked at it while standing still. He did nothing, and held himself to account for nothing, and decided nothing. **He only looked.**

And breaking off does not undo what came before

And the most dangerous thing about a stop is not the stop. More dangerous is what it says to you afterwards: **that you are back at the starting point, and that everything before it is gone.**

And that is not true. **A man who walked a month and then stopped a week has not gone back to zero.** You are not carrying a month of days, you are carrying what the month changed in you, and that is not wiped out in a week.

And take one picture that will stay with you: a man who had been writing something every day, one line, for a whole month. Then he was away for a week. Then he came back and opened the file, and looked at the date on the last line, **and selected everything and deleted it and closed it.**

Nobody deleted it for him. He deleted with his own hand what he had written with his own hand. The week he was away took not one line from him. What took the whole month was the three seconds after the week.

So breaking off is not undoing. The undoing is pulling down what came before, with your own hand, after the break.

And coming back is a door that does not shut

A man who came back to something he had dropped and regretted it has come back, he has not relapsed. The door is open, and no final sentence is passed on anyone, not by you and not by him.

And there is not one line in this book telling you that you are later than you are allowed to be.

The action

This chapter is read now and acted on the day you stop. So put a mark in it.

Dose	The act
Full	When you stop: come down to the smallest dose you have, and stay on it for seven days without increasing, and review nothing and hold yourself to account for nothing in it
Half	Do the smallest dose once in the week you stopped in
Smallest	Open your week sheet and look at it for a minute, and do nothing

The sign that you moved: you come back on the third day and not in the month after. **The difference between a man who comes back after three days and a man who comes back after a year is not in the will, it is that he knew coming back was allowed.**

The way out

In two lines

This is the last chapter, and its job is to graduate you. **A book you need in a year the way you need it today is a failed book**, however fond of it you are. This chapter tells you how to leave, what to take, and who to credit with what happened.

A woman a year on

A year had passed over a woman.

She sat one night with the feeling that the coming week was going to be heavy. **She did not open a book, and did not go looking for something to read, and did not ask anybody.**

She sat for two minutes and asked herself three questions: **where am I now? What is the thing that keeps repeating in me lately? And what is its opposite, that can be done tomorrow?**

Then she wrote one line on her phone:

“Before I unlock the shop, I write the most important thing of the day in one line, and then I unlock.”

And she gave herself a sign: that she finds the thing done without remembering when she sat to do it.

And that is all that happened. Three minutes.

She does not think of herself as using something she was taught. **She feels that this is her ordinary thinking.** If somebody told her she was following the steps in some book, she would say no, I am only sorting out my day.

And that is exactly the sign that she has left. What you take with you leaves its name behind and keeps its shape. **Whoever is still carrying the name is still carrying the book and not the tool.**

And if you are still opening the page to know the steps, you are still inside, **and there is nothing wrong with that. Only know where you are, because whoever does not know his place does not know what he needs.**

What you take with you

Not the book. **You take three things**, and all of them are already in your hands if you have done what came before:

The first: you know where you are standing. Six layers, four circles, and a difference between something passing and something that lives in you. A man who knows his place no longer repairs the roof while the foundation leans.

The second: you know how to write an act that can be done. Small, hung on something that happens, with a sign, and able to shrink. **That is a skill that serves you in everything in your life, not only in what is in this book.**

The third: you know what to do when you stop. And that is the dearest of the three, because everyone who ever dropped something in his life dropped it in the moment he stopped and did not know what to do.

And how you know you have left

By one sign: **you find yourself writing an act for yourself without opening a page.** And a week passes in which you needed nothing from here, and then two weeks.

When that happens, put the book in its place on the shelf. **And do not think you have given something up; that was what was asked of you.**

One who left holding on, not holding a tool

And against her, another.

A man walked in something like this for a whole year, **and genuinely changed.** He began sleeping early, and being present with his children, and holding his answer back an hour instead of losing his temper in the moment. All of that is real, and nobody can say he did not change.

Every time somebody asked him, he said the name of the thing he had walked in. And he recommended it to everybody who complained to him. And he opened it every night long after he no longer needed to open it.

After a year the thing stopped. It closed, or it changed, or he moved away from it.

In three months he was back as he was.

Not because what he learned was lost, **but because he never saw that he had learned anything.** He saw something outside him keeping him moving, and himself as well while he stood beside it. **And the thing went, and he went with it.**

And that is the most dangerous way to leave, because it looks like a year of success. Nobody will tell you that you are wrong, because every sign was good.

And the difference between the two is not in what they did, nor in how much they kept to it. The difference is the answer to one question, and you ask it of yourself while you are still in the middle, **not at the end of the year, where the answer arrives as news and not as a question.**

And do not credit us with it

And this is the last piece of advice in the book, and the truest.

If your life has widened, this book is not the cause of it, and neither is the app. **A book is pages and pages do nothing, and an app is a pulse that comes and goes,** and what did it is that you got up night after night and did one small thing while finding no taste in it.

Do not credit the book with it, and do not credit yourself as though you did it alone.

The work is on you, and none of it came from you alone: **the people around you and the circumstances that came were part of it,** and among

them is someone who made something easier for you without your asking, and among them is a day that came light when it could as easily have come heavy.

And a man who credits a book or a programme or a teacher has hung the width of his life on something outside himself, **so when that thing is absent his life narrows again and he does not know why.**

If this thing vanished tomorrow, would you still
know what to do?

Ask yourself that question while you are still in the middle of it, **not at the end of the year.** If the answer is yes, you are holding a tool. If the answer is no, you are holding on to something.

And that is the difference between leaving with a tool and leaving with an attachment. **And attachment is one of the twenty two, so take care not to leave the book carrying one of them.**

The action

The act of this chapter is to try walking without it, while you can still come back to it.

Dose	The act
Full	Close this book and the app for a whole week, and draw your week sheet by hand on paper of your own : name your circle, what you are working on, what you have hung it on, the three doses, and the sign. From memory, without opening a page
Half	Close them for three days and draw it
Smallest	Close them for one day and write three lines on any paper: where I am, what I am working on, what I have hung it on

The sign that you moved: you draw the sheet from memory and do not find a box you left out. **The shape is inside you now, and the app was only where you kept it until it was kept. A man who still needs the screen in front of him has not left. He has only moved his attachment from one thing to another.**

And one last thing

You will not become a different person. **You will be yourself in a wider space.** That is everything you were promised on the first page, and you were promised nothing else.

So if life narrows around you in a year, come back and open the week sheet, and write one small act, and hang it on something that happens in your day.

That is what you know now, and did not know when you opened this book.

Last page · and the week sheet

The sixteen acts on one page

Not so you do them. So that when you need one you can find it without hunting. Everything below is the **smallest dose** of its chapter, because the smallest dose is the one that gets done on a heavy day.

	Chapter	Its smallest dose	p
1	A man who knows everything and does not move	One word for the narrowing, any word that comes to you	6
2	Your life did not get narrow overnight	Turn off one notification for one app, tonight	13
3	The heart is a mirror and dust settles	Do not stop it. Just name it to yourself in the moment you are doing it, and say “this is it”	19
4	Why one act widens you and the same act narrows you	Before the act, say to yourself who you are doing it for. One word, then carry on	25
5	Six layers	Answer one question: how many hours a night did you sleep this week, on average?	31

	Chapter	Its smallest dose	p
6	Something passing and something that lives in you	Write today's date and one word for your state, and look at the sheet in two weeks	36
7	The twenty two, in plain words	Put a mark next to one, and write nothing	42
8	Every ailment is treated by its opposite, and the root is love	Write the opposite in one line, in the form of an act and not in the form of a quality	54
9	Yourself	The smallest version of the same act, not an easier different act. If you chose walking, the smallest is to walk for one minute, not to read about walking	61
10	Your home	One question you ask, and then you are quiet until the answer is finished, however long it takes	66
11	Your work	Not replying to one work message after an hour you choose tonight. One only	71
12	Your people	One message in which you ask for nothing and reply to nothing	77

	Chapter	Its smallest dose	p
13	The day · one act, three doses	Write the thing it hangs on, on its own. Anything that happens in your day every day without exception	83
14	The week · five and one and open	Name your open day and nothing else	89
15	When you stop	Open your week sheet and look at it for a minute, and do nothing	96
16	The way out	Close them for one day and write three lines on any paper: where I am, what I am working on, what I have hung it on	102

One line at the end of the road

Everything in this book comes back to one sentence: **the shape is fixed, and one thing inside it changes.**

One sheet filled in fifty two times. And one act in the week, not two. And three doses, no more. **That fixedness is what makes the thing possible,** because you are not taking a new decision every week, you are filling in a shape you already know.

The week sheet

The box	What you write in it
Where I am now	Which of the four circles: myself, my home, my work, my people
What I am working on	A word or two. One, not two
What it hangs on	Something that happens in my day anyway: the first time I sit down, after the last meal, before sleep. I am the one who chooses it
The act · full dose	
The act · half	
The act · smallest	The same act, smaller, not a different easier act
The sign	How I know I moved. Something I can touch, otherwise it is talk
Seven boxes	Day by day: Done · Smaller. A counter, not a chain, and there is no box for failure

And one last thing to say

You were not promised in these pages that you would become someone else, or that what weighs on you would lift, or that your life would turn over in thirty days.

You were promised one thing: that your life would become wide enough for what is in it. And that when it narrows again, you would have in your

hand something you know how to do.

And that is enough.

PART FIVE

The app

The book teaches the shape. The app runs it with you: one article a week, one pulse a day, and one sheet filled in fifty two times.

Why there is an app

The book has finished its work here. It told you why life got narrow, what you are made of, the four circles, and how to walk through a day and a week. **All of that is knowledge, and knowledge was never what you lacked.**

What you lacked was something that comes to you every day at its time, at a size you can manage today; that knows you are tired and makes the thing smaller instead of stopping; and that knows you did not come, without punishing you for it. Those three things paper cannot do. **Paper waits for you to open it. The app comes to you.**

So the app is not an addition to the book. **It is its working half.** The book teaches the shape, and the app runs it with you: one article a week, one pulse a day, and one sheet filled in fifty two times. There is nothing in it the book did not say.

And nothing in it that the book refused: no streak of days, no percentage, no praise and no blame, no button called Skip, and no reminder of a day you missed. **Its success is the book's success: that you need it less.** After a year the shape is inside you, and you leave it.

You enter with an email and a password. Settings then shows your recovery code: **write it on the last page of this book.** If you change phone or forget the password, it brings you back.

The journey inside the app

When you enter, it asks you three things and no more: your time zone, which it takes from your phone; what your open day is called and who you will tell; and which circle you start from. Then the first sheet.

THE YEAR

Fifty two weeks, thirteen for each circle, in the order you chose. Each week one trait of the twenty two, and one article about it. You do not read the articles ahead of their week, because an article is not reading. **An article is the week's instructions.**

THE WEEK

The first day: the week's article, and at its end one suggested act in three doses. Pin it to your sheet with one tap, or write your own. Then fill the week sheet, the same sheet you will see on the next pages. From the second day the sheet locks: **the act does not change in the middle of the week. The dose does.**

Five acting days: one pulse each day. **One question day:** a single question with three answers; you tap one, and there is no right one. **And the open day:** nothing at all. Not even a line saying it is open.

THE DAY

The pulse is one minute in one voice: where you are today, then your act at today's dose, then your sign. It arrives the evening before, so that whoever hung his act on the morning hears it at night and does it with the phone far away. **Under it two buttons, not three: Done, and Smaller.** And you tap after you do it, not before.

THE DOSE

Done: the dose stays as it is. Smaller: it goes down one step, and the smaller one comes to you on the spot. You did not come: it goes down one step without a word. **Silence means the dose was too big, not that you failed.** And at the start of every week it returns to full.

THE NOTEBOOK

The month is a grid, and above it one line: how many days passed, and on how many you moved. **A counter, not a chain.** It does not reset, it does not break, and there is no box for failure. From the notebook you go back to any past week: its sheet and its article.

THE WAY OUT

After a year the shape is inside you. Then draw it on paper of your own, from memory, as the act of chapter sixteen asks, and leave the app. **A man who still needs the screen in front of him has not left.** And if life narrows again years later, sign in again. Your sheet is waiting.

ONE WEEK AS IT FELL

Daniel • 34 • Manchester • teacher

He took the first circle because his sleep was a wreck and he knew it.

What he picked from the twenty two is not the worst thing in him.

It is the most repeated: he reaches the end of the day unable to say what was in it.

And the thing he hung it on is not a pleasant event. It is one that happens anyway.

The next page is the week sheet as it appears in the app, filled in as an example. The numbers on it are explained on the page after it.

THREE RULES THAT GOVERN THE SHEET

- 1 The act hangs on something that happens, never on a time on the clock.
- 2 The smallest dose is the same act made smaller, never an easier different act.
- 3 Two answers only: Done and Smaller. There is no box for failure.

1 Where I am now

Myself

My home

My work

My people

2 What I am working on

one word or two, not two things

The day passes and I am not in it

3 What it hangs on

something that happens in my day anyway, and I choose it

when I put the keys on the table

The act, in three doses

the smallest is the same act made smaller, not an easier one

4 Full

one silent minute, no phone

5 Half

thirty seconds

6 Smallest

one breath before I stand up

7 The sign

something you would notice, not something you count

I can name one thing from the day without opening my phone

8 The week

Mon	Tue	Wed	Thu	Fri	Sat	Sun
Done	Done	Done	Done	Done	question	open
Smaller	Smaller	Smaller	Smaller	Smaller		

The eight fields

1 Where I am now

Circle one of the four. Not two.

2 What I am working on

One word or two. One thing, not two.

3 What it hangs on

Something that already happens in your day. You choose it, not us. A time on the clock passes over you while you are in something else; an event happens to you, so you remember.

4 The act, full dose

Small enough to make you laugh. If you said this is too small to be worth writing down, you have the size right.

5 Half

The same act, half the amount.

6 Smallest

The same act, smaller. Not an easier different act. If the act is walking, the smallest is one minute of walking, not reading about walking.

7 The sign

How you know you moved. Something you can touch. Be better is not a sign. Sleep with the phone outside the room is a sign.

8 The seven boxes

Write the names of your days once, and the app keeps them for every week. The week is not the same in every country or every job: five acting days, then one question day, then one open day. Then day by day: Done, or Smaller. A day with nothing in it is not a failure, it is news that the dose was bigger than the day.

THE WEEK AS IT FELL

Daniel

Mon	<i>Wrote the page. Spent the minute planning tomorrow</i>	Done
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Tue	<i>Easier. Stayed the whole minute</i>	Done
-----	--	------

Wed	<i>Home at eleven. One breath and that was it</i>	Smaller
-----	---	---------

Thu	<i>Nothing. Remembered it in bed</i>	
-----	--------------------------------------	--

Fri	<i>Named something from the day without looking it up</i>	Done
-----	---	------

Sat	<i>Do I shut the laptop settled, or am I running? Running</i>	question
-----	---	----------

Sun	<i>Walked. Did not open the work email</i>	open
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THE SIGN, AT THE END OF THE WEEK

One day I remembered before the phone. One.

END OF THE SECTION

One sheet, fifty two times.

The sheet you have just seen is all you will ever fill, fifty two times, and it lives in the app. Create your account, and write your recovery code in the box below. And if one day you find yourself writing it from memory without opening anything, you have left already.



Write your recovery code
here

You find it in the app, under Settings. It brings you back if you change phone.